ahead. It was in arithmetic and algebra that India kept the lead. The inventor or inventors of the decimal place-value system and the zero mark are not known. The earliest use of the zero symbol, so far discovered, is in one of the scriptural books dated about 200 **B.C**. It is considered probable that the place-value system was invented about the beginning of the Christian era. The zero, called *shunya* or nothing, was orignally a dot and later it became a small circle. It was considered a number like any other. Professor Halsted thus emphasizes the vital significance of this invention: 'The importance of the creation of the zero mark can never be exaggerated. This giving to airy nothing, not merely a local habitation and a name, a picture, a symbol but helpful power, is the characteristic of the Hindu race from whence it sprang. It is like coining the Nirvana into dynamos. No single mathematical creation has been more potent for the general on-go of intelligence and power.'!

Yet another modern mathematician has grown eloquent over this historic event. Dantzig in his 'Number' writes: 'This long

**Quoted in Hogben's 'Mathematics for the Million', (London, 1942).*

tG. B. Halsted: 'On the Foundation and Technique of Arithmetic', p. 20 (Chicago,